

Cornernoia

A Parable of Sacrifice

"The year is 2122, and I am a Trawler. I'm recording this for the good of future persons, who will likely want to know of some of the exploits of our movement in the historical narratives of future archival databases.

"The historical narrative, as it is, is decided by those with the power, and those who have the power have it because they have the money, and those who have the money are those who have pushed their way to the top: boards of executives and CEOs. The kind of headless raffle you'd find in a chair room—aside from the chairs.

"My name's not important, or at least I don't think so. It could've been any one of us choosing to put ourselves on the line for this. Maybe it's because we have nothing to lose, or maybe it's because of just how much we have to gain.

"My story, though—our story—I do believe is important, and though it will probably never be told; not formally, not in the mainstream; I think it should endure. That's why I'm recording this; anything I can leave behind, no matter how small, increases the chances that something will survive.

"A shuttle probe doesn't leave you a lot of space to hide a little camera around, it's barely got the room for just me; so I hope you don't mind this frontal helmet shot here. If it's too close for comfort, know that it is for me too, so put up with it for a minute.

"As you can see, it really is pretty compact in here. I hardly have more room than to lie flat on my stomach. Minimalist, as well: launch lever, steering controller, oxygen metrics, fuel metrics, radar scanner, this little joystick for complex maneuvers here, a place for your bathroom needs that's hopefully out of shot; maybe some other custom doohickeys if you had a good builder, and what more do you need?

"The radar tends to be a piece-of-crap, cosmic background microwave radiation interferes with it quite a bit so unless you got a good tech guy to give it some baseline blocker you'll get a lot of staticky interference.

"But that was in the nature of things off-the-beaten path of corporate cleanness. A corporation sells you something that is easy to use, softened around the edges so that you can not make any mistakes they didn't want you to. Anything that doesn't work quite right is deliberate, anything that does is made to make you not think about the stuff that doesn't.

"I'm getting off-topic, though. My former life as a QA Tester for Tiny Software still gets the best of me sometimes, try as I might to forget. The launch site takes care of most of the hard stuff, thankfully. I'm no rocket scientist, just someone sick of getting thrown down onto the pavement every month when rent's due. All I have to do is press this fuchsia button and flick this silver knob.

"So then, while this system warms up here and the coordinates near-enough to the station I'm targeting are calculated, let me explain a bit about who we are. We from Down to Earth LLC: that stands for 'limited liability company', if that acronym is lost in the future. For all I know, we won't even have companies one day. I don't think I would hate that.

"But Down to Earth is different from other companies—and not in that facetious way where we try to convince people that we're a healthier alternative as some sort of marketing gimmick. I mean it quite literally, even legally. We're not quite classified as a company in the Corporation Index.

"Ah, right, that kind of thing might not exist anymore either. It's hard to know exactly what kind of world I'm recording this for, just that it's ideally a better one.

"See, the Corporation Index is—well—corporations are in control, right? They're hierarchies, sort of like a pyramid-shape, where at the wide basin everyone is beaten and abused, and the money flows upward to the top like hot air rises.

"Their main mission, besides accrue more money, is to accrue more assets that allow them to accrue more money. That means personnel, tools, marketing campaigns, even other companies—especially other companies.

"And when these companies own one company, they want another company. Rival companies merge and become one company as the larger duck eats the smaller duck—least, I think that's how ducks work; we haven't had them in Wenevernamedit City since before my time.

"So the Corporation Index keeps track of these conglomerates. Who's at the top, who's a subsidiary of who, and whose stocks are at what price.

"Down to Earth LLC isn't owned by any parent company. From what I understand, this used to be known as a start-up. It's a little side effect of the system called Capitalism that we live in that got hunted to extinction by the bigger names about a half-century ago.

"Even more unusually, it's in-part open source. The designs we use, the technology we invent, even the programs; it's all put out into cyberspace and free for anyone to use, protected under a little forgotten paragraph of copyright law called the guh-noo license. And if that sounds like an animal from the Northern United Africas, I don't blame you, but it's actually an acronym. G-N-U. Stands for... something or other. Truth be told that's not really the part of this organization I handle, I'm just trying to give you people of the future a background about what's going on."

My trailing monologue was cut off by a digitized beep and an alert on the interface screen a couple feet in front of my face.

Orbital launch commencing shortly, it read. It was nice having a screen of text not automatically read out to you in an AI-generated voice—just a quick beep to grab your attention. It struck me as quaint. In my time in quality assurance, you wouldn't believe the number of awful alert systems I had to endure.

I closed my eyes and prepared. Soon, I would be just 60 miles within range of Commercial Utopopolis, the largest shopping mall project in the world—or out of it.



It takes around 3 hours to reach the space station, a feat that is owed to tossing the probe in alignment with the Earth's rotation to get some extra speed. And there it was, a distance away in space that was difficult to approximate with the naked eye due to the complete and utter lack of landmarks that existed in the vacuum of space.

It was huge, a dead monument to excess. It cast a shadow over my probe the likes of which would be unfathomable on Earth, even in a city built primarily of skyscrapers. This part always made my blood cold and my skin bumped. It was as if you'd taken the first step into the realm of giants and the Colossus stood before you.

But I wasn't going to admit that part to the camera.

I was lucky, the side I faced it from was blocking the sun. Though this made it hard to pinpoint key details about the station's exterior that I knew it had—such as its nauseatingly gauche neon color scheme or several digitized billboard advertisements affixed to its sides that were in varying states of disrepair—it did protect from the searing radiation and heat of this solar system's largest fusion reactor.

"My job now is to find an entrance," I said suddenly to the camera after hours of silence. "I can't just use the docking port they would've used for actual ships, because this probe is not built to survive that. And I can't use the intake they would've used for cargo for the same reason."

"Thankfully, I have a little rubber button that controls the headlights, which will make that job a lot less like pissing in the dark," then I pointed to a little textured orange nub underneath the probe interface.

I pushed it, and a dim light came into view through the probe's external camera feed. I pushed it again, and the light became brighter.

"If I push it again, it'll start blinking. Then if I push it *again*, it'll start blinking rapidly. Then I can press it again to turn it off. So, yeah, I consider that an example of bad design."

I gripped the probe controller (which had two thumbsticks and some buttons not unlike a video game controller of old, back when people had time for things like that) and move the right analog stick up and left gently; then down and left, then right, then up and right.

The sheer size of the space mall's exterior would make this akin to the ancient proverb of finding a needle in a haystack. Everywhere there were sealed windows, maintenance panels welded shut, and exhaust vents that likely didn't lead anywhere especially safe.

"I have two arms in front of the probe, to be clear," I started explaining. "One is for grabbing: it can pry things apart, pick things up—it's basically a big claw. The other is a welder. It can melt metal so that it's easier to pry, or weld it if I want to lock something behind me.

"So I have options on how to get in, I just need to pick the one that I don't think will lead to a leaking carbon monoxide vent or something similar. I have this entire wall..." and to emphasize what I meant I panned from left to right showing nothing but a sleek cyan blue expanse, "...to scour, so I'll be here in the weeds for a while.

"Did I ever mention that these probes only contain 24 hours of oxygen?"



At last, sweating from the tedious concentration I'd been putting up with for the past 45 minutes or so, I had narrowed down my potential points of entrance to two vents, which were coincidentally directly next to each other.

I pressed X on the controller: one of the buttons on the right side aligned like a plus, and the probe's claw gripped one of the vents. I positioned myself in front of it just so, then began to peel it off like a sticker.

When I got to be about halfway done with the peeling process, however, my screen was suddenly assaulted by a puff of smoke, clouding up the camera and completely blinding my view of the outside.

"The hell?"

Quickly, I pressed the right bumper button on the controller. Thinking I ought to explain myself, I brought it into focus of the camera.

"This button here, it's mapped to the probe's chemical analysis—far and away the least cheap part of its design. It's designed to take in only about a micron of a gas in front of you, charge it with a small electron beam, and use that to determine the mass and charge of a substance—and ergo, its identity. These little probe computers come pre-equipped with a whole library of chemical information.

"And if that all sounds pretty complex, don't worry, I'm just repeating what someone else said to me. I don't have a degree in Chemistry to understand this stuff—very few people do, given what a rare privilege college is today. There are some interesting characters among Down to Earth's ranks.

"I have no idea how we, the ragtag group we are, acquired technology like this; only that you have to be a trustworthy Trawler to earn the right to use one of these equipped probes. They're saved for missions like this one, where I'm puncturing the seal on a station we haven't started scrapping yet. There could be all sorts of unknown microatmospheres inside, see, so I need to be able to know what I'm up against."

The screen beeped and a little white sleeve (a remnant of the Sleeves operating system the interface was built on, designed by Robert Fence for his company TinySoftware) opened with some ASCII Art (which apparently stands for "Awesome System Can, Incredibly, Imply Art if modern history books are to be believed) depicting the chemical skeleton of the analyzed substance.

It had two H's with lines connecting to an O. It was bent slightly, like an elbow. Four little dots hovered above the O, two groups of two perpendicular to one another.

"Steam? It's just steam? Who's boiling water in here?!" I asked rhetorically, sneaking a comical glance at the camera.

I maneuvered the ship in front of the other vent and opened that one instead. I waited for another puff of gas like you would wait for that puff of air at the optometrist, but it never came.

"I guess this one, then."

Once opened, the vent shaft was just large enough for the shuttle probe, no more than two inches on either side.

"This is the part that requires the most training," I explained to the camera. "These shuttle probes may be built airtight enough to survive space, but they're not exactly durable under these circumstances. They're already trying to resist the differential pressure between the in-here and the out-there.

"That is to say, you should minimize bumps and scratches to the hull. I've got veeeery little wiggle room here, so I'm probably gonna... go... quiet, while I, uh... y'know..." I paused, "...focus."

The shafts were winding, and full of dead-ends: places like gas reservoirs or boilers. I just needed some sort of path to the interior of the mall. One especially hopeful series of twists and turns just led to a room with nothing but a big spinning turbine; I couldn't enter that without getting chopped to pieces.

"Who needs a giant turbine room? Never, and I mean NEVER, get me started on some of the stupid shit rich people will build into the design of these places just because they think it's 'neat' ".

I was getting nervous from the amount of time being taken. I had 24 hours. Seems like plenty of time, right? But I had spent 3 getting here, and a little less than 1 searching for an entrance. That was 4 already.

Then take into account I'll probably want around 3 hours of oxygen for my trip *back*, and I was already down 7 hours. Every second I spent getting in was a second I would also have to account for when I was getting out.

I took one deep breath, and held it. Then exhaled.

There wasn't enough oxygen in here to be getting panicked. There was another promising path just a few turns ago. I'll try that one next.

When I followed it, I was able to get just above a large overhead fan that would've overlooked the mall and cooled down its haughty and high-paying customers. Lucky for me, this fan was no longer powered. I was able to gently float past its blades and bend open the grate that was standing between me and the Commercial Utopopolis's interior.

What a sight it was, or must've been. It was sleek and shiny like a retro-futuristic Googie diner of the 1950s. Fake plants with their vibrant greens hid fake birds-of-paradise with their vibrant blues, violet spotlights spun and whirled in preset patterns, landing on mannequins in storefronts and on billboards for clothing brands. Even up here, fifty feet above it all, I could tell you exactly where the food court was by its giant checker-patterned sign and plastic hamburger.

It was a treasure trove, and like any treasure trove, it carried with it its air of foreboding. I was glad to be out of the cramped space of the vents, but something still felt wrong here.

I didn't like it.

I didn't like how the power was still on in some places and out in others. I didn't like the sporadic nature of what had been taken and what had been left.

Advertisements for movies that had come and gone with no one to remember them stood proud on banners over the mall like ghosts; this was not what made me uneasy.

Lights that were behaving perfectly normally one second would start flickering in patterns as if they were trying to lead me somewhere; shockingly, this is still not what made me feel uneasy. Human brain is always trying to find patterns, right? It could easily just be serendipity.

I guess I didn't know what it was then that made me feel so sick. Only that in this giant space, I felt boxed in. In a way, I guess I was. I knocked on the top of the probe from the inside, then glanced at the camera wondering how insane I must look.

For a second there, hovering in microgravity just above the remains of a shopping mall so far outside of my class I never would've been able to see it when it was at its height of activity, I felt like a very small kid.



"I didn't take into consideration how much of this video would just be silence," I spoke up suddenly after a long period of the aforementioned silence. I was poking at the fastening strap that was holding a dress in place from floating about senselessly in microgravity.

"I feel pressured to try to commentate because there's an implied audience. Turns out though, I'm not that good at that.

"Let me chip in now then, I've been exploring these stores for the past, uh," and I check the clock on the probe's interface, "forty minutes or so. I've found plenty of valuable things, y'know—every piece of scrap metal, cloth, plastic, anything—that's stuff that I can bring back to Earth for people who wouldn't have it otherwise. So in that sense, nothing here is valueless.

"...But I'm looking for a big prize. Something to really cement myself, and make it feel worthwhile that I was recording it. An example of the kind of thing I might be hoping to find would be something like, uh, a pallet of medical supplies. Or one of those banned 3D printers that can make a bunch of necessities without needing to go through corporate channels.

"Or maybe a piece of tech that could help Down to Earth out. Something that we can outfit in a probe to make subsequent missions even more successful. These probes only have these little cargo beds just underneath where I'm lying here, like an aluminum stomach. Through some pretty clever engineering you can distend it the more you need to put in it, and shrink it when it's empty.

"So far though, just a bunch of dead remains of overpriced clothing boutiques with their supply left on the same mannequins they were in the late 2070s.

"Again, not valueless, any clothing I take home could clothe somebody who can't afford it. I took a couple things like socks, underwear, pants... but I just feel like I should bring back something better."

I went silent for a long while after that. It wasn't until I hit a certain point of ennui floating above the focal point design piece of the mall's central fountain (a unique design which would shoot pressurized water from one side and catch it in the other, which probably required pretty frequent water changes because of how much airborne filth would get caught in it) that I spoke again.

"Jabbing at the remains of humanity with a prod like this makes me feel like an alien. Everything looks so inviting here and all I can do is fly around it in a pod. To add an extra irony to that feeling, this environment was never designed for people to begin with: only the megarich."

I could get out of this pod and float around if I really wanted to. The rate at which oxygen leaked out of the station had to be pretty slow, only slightly faster now after I opened that vent path to expedite it. It was still a microatmospheric environment with nitrogen, and oxygen, and those good things.

There were pitons and handrails made for flinging yourself around and catching yourself in microgravity. I could leave this pod if I *really* wanted to.

My motivation was draining and my head was killing me. I still hadn't found anything I was hoping for. As 40 minutes turned to 2 hours, I had to wonder when I would just start taking

anything around and making sure I could get to the Orbitos Launcher on top of the station and make it home.

My wandering had begun to lead me away from the stores and into employee-only areas. I didn't know what I was looking for, I was just gently propelling myself through the halls, opening and peeking into storage cabinets and offices. Many of the walls and closets were supplied with space suits, complete with air tank and pressurizer.

I found that interesting, in that sort of *I guess that makes sense* kind of way. Just as any facility should have fire extinguishers supplied on the wall in the case of an emergency, a space station should probably have emergency atmosphere suits around. My only concern was how few suits there were compared to how many people there would've been in the mall.

So few would survive.

But man, you'd really be surprised how many offices this mall has. If I didn't know any better, I'd say they were up to more than just a shopping mall up here—like categorizing and storing shopper information or something like that. Come to think of it, that doesn't seem so unlikely.

Eventually I ended up in a small office with just one desk, three filing cabinets, and one computer.

Well, the computer was as good as deadweight to me. Computers exist back on Earth already, arguably too many of them. And it's not like I could just boot it up and start browsing data, I was stuck inside an airtight space pod.

But the filing cabinets might be worth a search. I moved to try to pick one up, gently.

It bent in on the sides as the giant pneumatic claw punctured it. I suddenly felt a flash of empathy for how scary a lobster must be if you're a small sea mollusk on the ocean floor. Unlike ducks, I was plenty familiar with lobsters and mollusks. They're grown in bioaquariums all over Wenevernamedit.

I shook the cabinet around a little so that its contents would go flying and floating around the room, hopefully not with enough force that they'd stick themselves to any surfaces. Peeling a piece of paper off a table was hard enough when you weren't using big clumsy mech hands.

"I know this might seem kinda trite, just ransacking any random old thing I come across, but I have a good feeling about papers left behind in an old mall. They're either financial reports that were deliberately left behind because they probably hinted that they cooked the books a bit, which would be funny, or some other second mysterious thing."

A paper snowstorm buffeted the room, and I was caught trying to read whatever pieces were flying past my camera. Luckily, it had a zoom function.

"Damn. Looks like these are just employee records. *Physical* employee records.

"*Alan Joki*: janitor," I read out loud as a page floated gently past. "They kept physical records of their janitor? Volunteer: Yes? The hell does that mean?"

But aside from that momentary confusion, it amounted to not much else. Time feeling sufficiently wasted, I continued down the back halls of the dead old mall.



The mall was big, and felt even larger when you had to float through it at a snail's pace using magnet propulsion, all the while harboring an intense fear of what might happen if you bump into the wrong surface.

The number of enterable stores was slim, most were shackled down and gated off. The number of brand-names that stuck it out to the end were few. Odd, since most of them shared the same parent companies.

With a mall designed only for the elite, I wasn't entirely sure what they would be selling here. The designer-brand clothing, jewelry, watches, accessories—this was all obvious, and unfortunately fairly worthless to bring back to Earth. If someone needed clothes they'd want something to keep them warm, not some two-piece sequin crop-top/tube skirt with five zippers.

I addressed the camera:

"I'm not sure who all these hobby shops were for because to my understanding, the elite that this place was designed for don't really have hobbies. They might play golf in a giant isolated biodome, but golf isn't really a hobby so much as a thing about appearances.

"Those who are the top of the food chain lack the creativity for video games, television, and books. After all, they got there by drinking the creative blood of others. I'd compare them

to a certain blood-sucking monster of old myth, but unfortunately, that name has been held in copyright protection for the past 50 years.

"I can only come to the conclusion, then, that these kind of hobby and merchandise shops are here only to serve the aesthetic of a mall, so that the rich could roleplay the idea when actual shopping centers that weren't full of the sweating starving masses died out.

"Would you ever see a CEO go to a woodworking shop like this?" and I gestured to the Wood You Like To Have Some Fun store in the near-distance, "I don't think so. What does a CEO want to woodwork for? He can hire five woodworkers, pit them against each other, and only pay the best one. Human labor is like sport."

Each floor had to have had something like 50 storefronts, and according to a map posted around on glowing billboards, there had to be something like 30 floors.

The way you got from floor to floor were these giant spiral ramps, built in these large cylindrical amphitheaters, with these bizarre thin and winding windows that resembled the shape of potato peelings running down the walls so that you could see out into space. They were, I hoped, heat and ultra-violet resistant, given they were facing the sun.

The ramps left a bad taste in my mouth, something about them felt wrong, like a monument to a cosmic deity. If you tripped and couldn't catch your bearings, you'd keep falling down forever—though I guess in microgravity, that was never an issue.

On the ramps, in orderly columns stretching all the way to the top, lined adjacent to one another so that it looked like rivers of silver metal, were bars sticking out a couple inches

from the ground that could be used as hand holds. There were hand holds underneath the ramps as well, such that as you were climbing them in the spiral manner that it rose, you could be grabbing onto either the floor or ceiling.

All this detail was extraneous to explain to the recording, however. After all, it was all in view of the camera.

"Look at that," I said, and one would instantly understand.

Eventually, 4 hours later on a floor I'd lost track of the number of, I floated meaninglessly up to an open storefront with a big utilitarian sign in dreadful serious font reading: 'ETERNUM'.

It caught my attention, because a name like that is only for either something sinister beyond comprehension, or a cologne store.

A blue sign in the window exclaimed with all the authoritative might of a governmental document: 'LIVE FOREVER'. Which, could still be a cologne store.

Out of morbid curiosity alone, I went inside. Maybe I shouldn't have. I knew I had already spent half my time, only 12 hours remaining and I had to be on the journey back by that point.

Unlike most mall stores, with their big open entrances, this one had a pair of heavy doors. They did not open on their own like most doors back in Wenevernamed City do, so I had to pry my way inside. Whatever they were selling in here, they wanted to play up its mystique. Again, could still be cologne.

It was dark inside. And not because the lights were out, they were on; but they were these shaded cyan lights that made the whole room feel underwater—and a small room it was, only a reception desk in front of me.

It turned into a hall to the right, and from there I could enter the real room. Similarly dark, similarly blue, and filled with four by six columns of these pods, each of which was plugged into its own outlet on the ground.

They were difficult to describe, like operating tables but with a bulbous submarine affixed to the top. Like manila-colored torpedoes suspended in the air, tied to the ground.

Thankfully the task of describing them wouldn't fall on me; they were visible on camera, after all.

If floating around the Commercial Utopopolis had felt forbidden up to this point already, the atmosphere in this room was like being brought before your martial lord as a lowly serf knowing you had just pilfered from his lavish golden coffers.

Embedded lettering on the walls, embroidered words on office chairs, the branding and logos on left-behind computer cases, water bottles, and jackets: it all said 'LIVE FOREVER'.

"Okay, I think I know what this is. If you're from the future, you'll probably know what this is too.

"I've heard rumor about life-extension pods. Who hasn't? The adage used to be that the only thing money can't buy is the ability to live forever—but that became less true once we got cybernetic enhancements, didn't it?

"Now if you're rich, you can make yourself a robot and live forever. To many, this is satisfactory. It's a figured-out solution, for one, and it works. So why not buy and build yourself into some sort of walking automaton? Felon Dusk did it, and that's many-a technocrat frat boy's idol.

"But to my understanding—I mean, in the QA biz you hear people throw around rumors for stupid new products all the time, so I never really believed them—this pseudo-eternal life wasn't good enough for some. They didn't want to lose their bodies to metal.

"They would rather be sedated and kept alive through machinery that pumps their organs even when they cannot pump themselves, they'd rather live in the pulchritudinous dreams and lies of whimsy within their own subconscious for the rest of time.

"Kind of an interesting philosophical choice then, right? Would you rather choose to lose your body, but keep your consciousness? Or lose your consciousness, but keep your body? This is one way to find out what kind of essentialist these super-rich really are."

I paused for a while, mulling over my own words.

"Uh, I used to hang around a lot of philosophy types after high school before the College of Philosophy got demolished to make room for the world's first Ultramarket. So. This kind of stuff interests me, I guess.

"Well, assuming I'm right, these pods are all full of old rich people that chose to go the way of the vegetable rather than confront mortality.

"It's quite disturbing actually, thinking about it. They all chose to go to sleep in a mall forever. Then the mall shut down around them, without them ever knowing. Not that they could probably even fully comprehend what a mall is anymore, aside from the abstract concept of it.

"Well, nothing of value here for me."

And I said that, and I thought I felt it, but for some reason I kept hovering around anyway.

"It's weird, you know, that this is the first I'm seeing of this technology, built decades ago. That must've been one quiet patent.

"It's just confusing me. If it was successful, it would've seen widespread adoption; and it hasn't. And if it had issues, it would've undergone more testing—which means I should've seen it back when I was a QA.

"It's just absurdly odd. Maybe these were all just display models, maybe none of them actually work."

With reckless disregard for the air I had remaining, I couldn't help but sit here and think about this for a while. I set my controller down and was staring down the whole room through the tunnel-vision of my camera.

That's when I realized: a tiny red light on the outlet next to the pod closest to me on the left, first in line. It wasn't a surprising light, most electronics liked to have little lights to let you know they were powered on.

But that's exactly it: it was the only red light of its kind. Despite power clearly being functional in this store, only one pod was active.

Tentatively, I approached it. It had a computer interface—one that was hard to make out through the camera I was looking at it from. The screen looked like scanlines as it got aliased through the two screen displays.

But with the zoom function and some eye strain, I could just make out what it said. I read it out loud for the camera, because for all the issue I was having reading this screen through a screen, it would be even harder to see through the screen being used to watch the camera footage.

" 'PATIENT INFORMATION', it says. 'NAME: ALAN JOKI'. Age... wait, what the hell? Alan Joki, like the fuckin'... the, um... the *janitor* from that random employee record I read? That was multiple floors up. What are the odds of this?! Wh-what is he doing in here?! If there's ever been a janitor part of the mega-elite-super-rich Corporations That Which Govern—I mean, I don't even—shit! I'd be rich too!"

Then I remembered that serendipitous detail, that little piece of information that I read out on sheer whim to mock it. The fact that he was checked as a 'Volunteer' with no further specifics.

"Don't tell me...!" I said to myself incredulously, at this point having forgotten about the camera recording. "He was volunteering... for this?"

I continued reading in a voice of disbelief.

" 'AGE: 75. PRESERVED AGE: 35. SEX: M. HGHT: 173 cm. WGHT: 91 kg.' " I paused knowingly at the next section, anticipating something heavy. " 'SPECIAL NOTES:'... 'Asked to be put to sleep with photo of his son and daughter.' "

My face fell into my hands. Truly, this is the kind of despair you encounter as a Trawler that they don't prepare you for.

"C...Could he still be alive in there? I mean, the facility has power, right?" I asked no one. There was probably some button on the interface that would let you check his vitals, but I had no way of pressing it from within my pod. My claw would do nothing but destroy the screen.

Funny, that I was only feet away from the only other human life in hundreds of miles, and we were both trapped inside pods with no way to see one another.

Even if he was alive in there, how long would he stay that way? This mall was leaking electricity, leaking atmosphere; leaking any form of hospitability it ever had. This man, albeit however slowly, was dying.

I stared deeply at the picture of his family included in the Special Notes section.

He was a man with young kids, who weren't so young anymore. If he'd really been in this thing for 40 years, they'd have to be in their 50s now. If he'd really been in this thing for 40 years, he never got to see them grow up. He never got to be with them.

Why do it, then? Why volunteer for something like this?

Well, I can only guess the answer is probably those same kids. A janitor wouldn't have been able to afford a living for them, not in this world. That's why he took the job as a janitor in space, it would pay slightly better for the implicit dangers involved with being in space.

They probably gave him a healthy bonus for taking on that volunteer duty. Maybe promised to send money back to his kids. Maybe get them through whatever college programs are left in that damn city.

"I think..." I choked back some emotion, "I think I found my important cargo."



"After having spent some time thinking about it, there's a pretty plain issue here. If I unplug him and try to cram him in the cargo bay—even supposing it would fit—he'd suffocate in there. Those pods are their own private contained microenvironments. They're hooked up to a gas valve that lets air in from some distant supply.

"And even suppose that gas valve was ripped open so air could flow in freely, guess what: air doesn't flow through the cargo bay of this pod. That'd waste the already limited supply.

"Now it doesn't take a genius to see that that thing isn't going to fit in here with me, as well. So I could try opening it and taking him out, but it'd be too risky. I wouldn't want to risk the claw crushing the man inside like a tuna can—which is actually a remarkably difficult can to crush, come to think of it, but it can be done.

“So, I have an idea. And, it’s not a good idea. If they knew I was doing this, they wouldn’t let me be a Trawler; and they definitely wouldn’t let me pilot their probe with the expensive mass spectrometer. Step one of it looks like this.”

I flipped up a small plastic panel blocking a button, then pressed the button. The interface asked: ‘Are you sure?’, as any good interface should. But I was sure. And I was sick of things thinking I wasn’t sure.

It gave me a 10-second timer in which I could cancel. I didn’t.

Another prompt came up, asking if it should disable air flow. I told it that it should.

Then, it asked if I was sure again. I was.

With a hiss, the back of the probe began splitting into two half-spheres, as the warm air inside the pod rushed to fill the space of the freezing air out in the ETERNUM store of the Commercial Utopopolis.

Who knows how much air was left in this station, all I needed to know was that there was enough.

I grabbed the camera, unhinged it from its mount, and slid backwards out of the probe. I was free-floating in microgravity, free from that tiny space. I grabbed the side of a table and cracked my back; stretched my limbs as hard as I could.

Immediately after stretching, I got to work with the pod’s interface.

VITALS, I pressed.

“ ‘STATUS: ALIVE’, ” I read out for the camera, ignoring all the nitty-gritty details the page also displayed.

DREAMSCAPE, I pressed next out of curiosity.

“ ‘SYNOPSIS: Subject is to live happily with wife and kids in his hometown in the Finnish countryside. The biggest struggles in his life are minor familial disagreements, and the occasional poor harvest season. He lives humbly within his means and his family loves him.’ ”

“ ‘SPECIAL NOTE: This subject is to be included permanently on the PLATINUM subscription plan free-of-charge for his volunteering. As such, there is no need to inject nightmares or hysteria into his Dreamscape. It may seem like a waste of money, but we were given special orders.

-L’. ”

I hesitated.

In a way, he was already seeing his wife and kids every day. He had been for the past 40 years. In a pleasant life, instead of one of poverty in Wenevernamedit City.

Fantastic. Another little morality play; another philosophical parable. I get to live this one out.

But I already knew what I was doing. I only hope that Mr. Joki would understand.

“I guess my parable... is a Parable of Sacrifice,” I said plaintively, gazing knowingly at the camera in my hand.

I clicked the large, red, rectangular 'OPEN POD' button.

"Are you sure?" it asked in a digitized, feminine voice that spoke like it was trying to sell me the illusion of having an endearingly sassy personality. "This will abort the current Dreamscape."

I was sure.

The pod opened with a hiss as the warm air within rushed out to meet the freezing air of the mall.

Inside was a man who appeared to be in his mid-30s, devoid of clothing, hooked up to tubes. But besides the macabre nature of seeing a man wired up like a science fair potato battery, he seemed in fine condition.

He appeared to be in a deep sleep.

"...Alan?" I asked, thinking that that was the kind of thing you'd say in this kind of situation. I'd seen it in the movies.

"Subject will remain in a comatose state for around twenty-four to forty-eight hours," the computer voice chimed in suddenly, with comical timing. "Please take care during this time, and remember to roll the subject over on their side in case they vomit. Their body will have to reacclimate to controlling its own processes.

"And remember!" it added with an excited chirp, "there is a 1/10 chance of complete pulmonary failure. We'd like to remind you that in these circumstances, it's never your fault.

Happy Eternum! Live forever!” and it went out with a catchy jingle reminiscent of the 2020’s vapid hyperpop.

So now I was in the grand situation of standing over a completely comatose (and also completely naked) man, whom I had to find a way to ship 300 miles or so back to the surface of the Earth.

The good news of microgravity is that he wouldn’t be too difficult to lift and move about. I was going to do a little transfer: from one pod to another.

Once he was secure in the Shuttle Probe, I grabbed a piece of paper off whatever was nearest. It probably had important files on it, but I flipped it over to its back where it was all blank. I was lucky to also find a pen—on a space station, all pens are pressurized and specially made to work in microgravity.

I was really enjoying how many issues I *wasn’t* having, I wish everything in life could resolve so smoothly. Space-compatible pen and paper right when I needed them? You’d think I was in a dream... or a Dreamscape.

On the paper, I wrote a note.

Hello fellow Trawler, rural-living outlander, or loathsome corporate entity.

Fear not the naked man you have just opened out of a tin like a sardine.

I know he is not the treasure you were hoping for. Whether you were looking for a means to further our cause, a tomb to pilfer, or goods to confiscate, this man is none of those things.

Indeed, he is not related to Trawling or Down to Earth LLC at all. He was left in space to die a slow death, and separated from his family. He sacrificed his livelihood so that his family could live well.

I have chosen to pay that sacrifice forward. Do not worry about coming for me.

His name is Alan Joki. You will find him hopefully in a comatose state, and not dead of asphyxiation. Please check if he is breathing, but I choose to believe he will be found alive.

I beg of you, whoever you may be, to take care of this man until he recovers. Also preferably clothe him while he sleeps, because he will likely not respond to you very well if he wakes up naked. There are clothes inside this probe's cargo bay.

He has spent the past 40 years in a dream. I hope waking up is not the worst thing to happen to him.

Help him find his family.

Signed,

"Ah, damn it, ran out of ink," I muttered. "That's fine, it's not important who I am."

After I had finished writing, I placed the note, alongside the photo of his family, gently on the naked back of the man inside; then closed the pod by hand and gave it a good smack. Not many people knew this, but the interface inside was not the only way to initiate the probe's sealing protocol: this percussive method worked just as well.

"Don't worry about that," I told the camera, "when the ship seals it knows to turn the air flow back on. Our man isn't going to suffocate." I thought for a moment. "Sorry if the nudity thing stops this from being shown in schools one day. I didn't really know he would be like that in there."

The next part of my plan was to drag the probe alongside me as I threw myself from handrail to handrail inside the mall. I felt thrilled to be using my muscles again, feeling the cold air of a depleting atmosphere rush past my face. It was slick with the faintest signs of moisture, probably remnants from fountain spray.

I needed to get the probe to the top of the Commercial Utopopolis: that's where the Orbitos Launch Site would be. Unfortunately, it was also *outside* the Commercial Utopopolis. Which meant finding a way out. Which meant I would be in the cold, dead, hostile vacuum of space.

But to my great fortune, my prior wandering was not wasted.

*
**

I had dragged the probe to an employee hallway, and was filling up the oxygen tank of the probe with the emergency tanks beneath the space suits lined up in their lockers. It was an imperfect and messy process since I had to manually open and close the valve on both tanks, but I wasn't trying to be perfect—I just needed enough oxygen in the ship to buy Alan Joki a little more time once he got back to Earth.

If he was truly going to be in a comatose state for 24-48 hours, there was a non-zero chance he would still end up suffocating in the pod back on Earth—which would be a horrible and cruel irony, and I can't stand horrible and cruel ironies.

So as long as he was found before this probe ran out of air, he'd be fine. I was counting on it.

Next, I suited myself up in one of the atmosphere suits. I would be needing it where I was going. I was heading deeper into the labyrinthine halls of the employees only zone.

"I can't just leave the way I came in;" I addressed the camera from inside the suit, my voice likely muffled to the point of near inaudibility, "the caution I would have to exhibit guiding the probe back out the vent shaft aside, it would also be a near-impossible nightmare to climb that sheer-faced wall outside the station without a magnetic propulsion system.

"There aren't enough handle bars out there for that, and I'm not too keen on missing a grip and getting flung irrecoverably to a death in the stars.

"Instead," I emphasized my cleverness with hand movements, "I'm going straight to the top. It's a mall, right? Every mall has an elevator, and I think I have a good idea of where this one is.

"I also have a pretty good inkling that it'll have a secret maintenance airlock at the very top destination. And," I told the camera as I entered the elevator, where it stood guarded by two fake potted plants, "I figure I'd be able to guess the secret 'code' to input that will take me to this secret top floor."

I pulled the probe in alongside me, then pointed the camera at the elevator panel. There were 32 buttons, 34 if you included the Door Open/Close and Panic buttons.

I pressed and held floors 2, 3, 6, and 8, then pressed the Door Open/Close button with the hand holding the camera. It was barely possible with the stubby fingers of the atmosphere suit.

The elevator stuttered, then closed its door. I grabbed onto a handrail on the ceiling to ensure I wouldn't spend this ride flat against the floor. After a moment of calculation, the elevator began rising.

"This elevator is unique," I continued, "in that it requires no motors. It has no pulley and counterweight, it just works. It works, with magnets. Afterall, a regular elevator would be worthless in microgravity, right?"

I spoke with the self-assured authority of a valedictorian correcting the class.

"And we need not worry about the magnets interfering with the probe here," the probe in question having fallen gently to the floor in response to the elevator's rising, "as the magnetic propulsion design of the probe ensures that it was already designed with magnets in mind."

I paused to savor the dramatic irony of the moment.

"So how do I know all this? Well, you'll never guess what machine they use for training QA guys at the firm I worked at.

"Due to its many features, avant garde design, and expiration to the public domain, they train new hires with: the commercial space station elevator, by designer Minh Nguyen."

I smiled with satisfaction, but the camera probably couldn't see it through the visor of my atmosphere suit.

"Let's get this old custodian home."



When the elevator reached its assumed final destination, Floor 32, it stopped. The residual force sent me gently up to the ceiling. Then the elevator groaned. Something pneumatic was moving. A door was opening.

The elevator continued its ascent what felt like another several floors further. When it stopped again, I was already pushing against the ceiling so I wouldn't rise up and bonk it again.

The elevator's main light dimmed and the spinning red light activated as if the Panic button had been pressed, but no alarm sounded.

"That's the warning that tells you that an airlock is about to open, and that you should grab onto something or else be sent off into the vacuum of space. Also that if you're not in a suit, you should probably start writing a will in ten words or less.

"There's going to be no sound in a minute here, so you know, just expect that. Now hang on tight, I've gotta get a grip," I said as I placed the camera between my thighs.

I grabbed onto the handrail on the ceiling firmly with one hand, then held onto the shuttle probe's welding arm with the other.

"One of the design issues that we're supposed to note for class is the spontaneity at which the door—"

The elevator door opened, sending whatever residual air was in the elevator shaft surging outward into an abyss, dissipating into a million distant particles.

I let go of the handrail very carefully, and grabbed the camera from between my legs.

"One step at a time now," I said to myself in my suit, knowing the camera couldn't hear me.

I held on to the shuttle probe as tightly as I could, then made the smallest kick-off from the elevator toward the tar-black abyss in front of me.

I caught myself on the edge of the elevator door with the hand holding the camera, hitting the camera against the wall just a little.

"You're lucky you're such a small camera," I mouthed wordlessly and invisibly to it.

The maintenance elevator lead out directly onto what could be considered the "roof" deck of the Commercial Utopopolis, and but only a couple dozen feet away from the elevator was the Orbitos Launch Site.

It looked like a large array of cannons, each with a place you'd input a payload and a place that it'll get fired out. But it doesn't use gunpowder or rocket fuel, it uses magnets. The future is all magnets.

Carefully, with the precision of a rock climber on a sheer-faced cliff over a perilous canyon, I navigated handrail-to-handrail with my human man sarcophagus in tow.

I floated just feet away from one of the launchers.

"Stay there," I whispered purposelessly to the camera as I let go of it, leaving it to float in place. Despite maybe messing up its pitch, yaw, and roll a little bit, it mostly stayed put.

Lodging my foot in a hand rail to steady my place, I loaded the shuttle probe into the launcher. My eyes watered as I looked at the great blue ball of Earth, radiating from the light of the sun refracting against a billion surfaces, all of human life and existence serving together as one like a prism to make this moment for me.

"I hope they don't disappoint you down there, Mr. Joki," I spoke to myself, fogging up my visor, "I hope they don't make coming out of your dream a mistake."

I pressed the button to start launch, and grabbed the camera from where it was spinning in place.

"You'll be found when the time is right," I told the camera, and I pressed the button to stop recording. Perfect timing too, because its battery life died there immediately after.

As it calculated the launcher spun, aimed, spun, aimed, rotated, spun, aimed, and when it finished, it launched the pod like a ballista down to Earth.

The shuttle probe was sensitive to electromagnetism. When it detected the Earth's electromagnetic sphere intensifying, it would begin using its propulsion system to slow down. Alan Joki will survive the return trip at least, and will likely land somewhere just outside the city boundaries of Wenevernamed it.

I kneeled down to the best of the ability that the atmosphere suit would allow me, feet still lodged in the handrail for security, and watched as the pod became an increasingly smaller dot, an electron returning to its shell.

I knew I would have to go back down the elevator shaft soon, take the suit off, and probably see what remains I could find to eat in the food court. The best part of abandoned malls is everything is now 100% off.

But for now, I just wanted to watch.

```

      .....
      _____
      /...-.-==--.-.-.      """,
      .{ _..      \      /... .
      ./      \      /      | ,'.\` .
      /      :      ;'      \____> \
      :      \. (      /      :
      |      '>\_      \      r|
      /      \      \. _      \
      |      |      \      ;      |
      :      \      /      \      ;
      \      \.      \      \      /
      \.      |      /      ./
      \      \      /      . '
      \      \      /      . '
      \____\...-.-\

```

The Informal Acknowledgments

Column

Because it was never said that we need formal citations for our artifact!

- *The ASCII art globe on the previous page is a design I copied from this guy Kybernetikos on this website: <https://ascii.co.uk/art/globe>, it wasn't just a simple copy/paste job and I had to do some manual formatting to get it right, but the design is totally lifted! Thanks internet stranger!*
- *And for my inspiration of including an ASCII art thing at the end of a piece of art at all, I was thinking of the music video for Jonathan Coulton's All This Time, which does the same schtick. It's even space-related. But isn't it so humanizing and beautiful?*
- *I was inspired by John Scalzi's Redshirts, the novel from 2012, because I was reading it between bouts of working on this project and I think tonally it inspired me a lot. It both helped me realize some of what I wanted to write, and that I didn't have to be perfect when writing it. I mean, this guy finishes every piece of character dialogue with "x said", even if there's only two characters in the scene and you already know who's talking. Kind of drives me nuts. But still a great book!*

- *Alan Joki was named after Alan Wake from video game series Alan Wake by Remedy Entertainment. Since Remedy Entertainment is a Finnish company I figured I'd make a character named Alan with a Finnish last name. Come to think of it, the fact that he's a janitor with plot relevance also coincides with the character Ahti from the Alan Wake and Control universe. Man. I love Remedy Entertainment.*
- *In-world inventor Minh Nguyen is loosely named after real-world Flappy Bird creator Dong Nguyen.*
- *When I was picturing the space-walk finale of this story, I was thinking of the space-walk section toward the end of Alien Isolation, the video game released in 2014. They're not really that similar, it's just what I was thinking of.*
- *Come to think of it, I think those Dreamscape pod things I came up with are pretty similar to a thing in Fallout 4, I think there's dream pods in that also. It's a fairly recurring concept though, I know they touch on the concept for some gags in Rick*

& Morty, obviously being wired into The Matrix is a very popular and culturally enduring image; and there's dozens of other classic sci-fi movies talking about premises kind of like this. It's just a classic-ass sci-fi thing. So acknowledgments to all those sci-fi-ers who came before.

- *There's a line in Hotline Miami 2 from 2015 where the character 'The Son' says: "I've gotta get a grip!" and it has absolutely nothing to do with this story, I just really wanted to reference that for some reason. I reworded a scene to specifically include that wording even though it's not even remotely contextually related to that source material. So that counts as an inspiration, I guess.*
- *And an obligatory acknowledgment to every other inspiration swirling around the vortex of my mind that I can't conjure forth at will. Obviously there's several pieces of cyberpunk dystopian media this draws on, and I wouldn't even limit that to just Cyberpunk 2077 although that definitely is something I played and was probably subconsciously inspired by.*
- *This is the longest piece of writing that I've ever decidedly finished rather than left in a perpetual state of "being worked on" and "one day perfect", and I feel really happy about that. And for that I should acknowledge the professors of this class for*

giving me a deadline that actually made me finish a piece of writing. Thank you,

Stefan and Ian!